

ECON-361-001 Economic Development of Latin America

Fall 2025, Planetary Hall 224,

Meeting on Wednesdays, 7:20 pm -10:00 pm, in-person

Instructor: Eugenio Gerardo Garza Garza, PhD in Economics Candidate, egarzaga@gmu.edu

Virtual Office Hours: Tuesdays 3:00pm-5:00pm, via Zoom, or contact via email to accommodate.

Mason Core: [Mason Core, Global Understanding](#)

Specialized Designation: Non-Western Culture

Recommended Prerequisite: ECON 103 and 104 or permission of instructor.

Course description

This course studies the economic development of Latin America through a historical and contemporary lens, analyzing the region's experiences with economic growth and income inequality. Students will examine key topics such as colonial legacies and institutions, industrialization, trade liberalization, macroeconomic crises, and the role of formal and informal institutions in shaping development outcomes. Using country case studies and economic journal articles, the course explores how policy and markets interact to influence development trajectories.

As a Mason Core Global Understanding course, ECON 361 emphasizes cross-cultural perspectives and fosters the ability to critically compare economic systems and policy approaches regarding development outcomes across Latin America.

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

1. Analyze the diverse factors shaping economic development in Latin America.
2. Evaluate the effectiveness of different development strategies, including import substitution, export-led growth, and market-oriented reforms.
3. Interpret and compare economic indicators across Latin American countries using data and case studies.

4. Explain how external shocks, international commerce and policy have influenced Latin American economies.
5. Apply a global understanding framework to assess how culture and history interact in shaping development outcomes in the region.
6. Communicate well-supported arguments on economic development issues, integrating empirical evidence with theoretical perspectives.

Course structure

- **Reading Assignments:** each week, students are expected to complete the assigned readings before class. These readings provide the background and context needed for discussing in class.
- **Attendance and Class participation (10%):** Participation is based on completing the assigned readings before class and actively engaging in discussions. Students are expected to come prepared to contribute thoughtful comments, ask questions, and respond respectfully to peers.
- **Reading Reactions (25%):** before each class meeting, students must upload a reading reaction to Canvas. This should be a 1–2 page text of original thinking and expression in response to the week's readings. AI tools may not be used to write reading reactions.
- **Exams (45%):** the course includes a midterm (20%) and a final exam (25%), both consisting of handwritten essay questions. Exams will test your ability to explain concepts, apply theories, and analyze case studies covered in class.
- **Student presentations (20%):** students will select a Latin American country not covered in the course calendar and present it as a case study of economic development. Presentations may be done individually or in teams, depending on class size.

Grading

This course is graded on the [Undergraduate Regular scale](#). Assignments and exams are graded on a 0-100 scale. Final class grade will be calculated in the following way:

Final = $(0.10 \times \text{Participation}) + (0.25 \times \text{Reading Reactions}) + (0.20 \times \text{Midterm Exam}) + (0.25 \times \text{Final Exam}) + (0.20 \times \text{Student Presentation})$

98-100 = A+

93-97 = A

90-92 = A

88-89 = B+

83-87 = B

80-82 = B

78-79 = C+

73-77 = C

70-72 = C

60-69 = D

< 60 = F

Attendance and Late Policy

Attendance will be recorded at each class meeting and will count toward the participation grade. Arriving late will be noted and may lower your participation score. Late work will be accepted; however, points will be deducted for each day it is late, and feedback may be delayed. Students are responsible for catching up on any material missed due to absence or lateness.

Academic Integrity

It is expected that students adhere to the George Mason University Honor Code as it relates to integrity regarding coursework and grades. The Honor Code reads as follows:

“To promote a stronger sense of mutual responsibility, respect, trust, and fairness among all members of the George Mason University community and with the desire for greater academic and personal achievement, we, the student members of the University Community have set forth this: Student members of the George Mason University community pledge not to cheat, plagiarize, steal and/or lie in matters related to academic work.”

More information about the Honor Code, including definitions of cheating, lying, and plagiarism, can be found at the Office of Academic Integrity website at <https://oai.gmu.edu>

Global Understanding

This course fulfills GMU's Global Understanding requirement. The goals of the Global Understanding courses consist in the following four learning outcomes:

1. Identify and articulate one's own values and how those values influence their interactions and relationships with others, both locally and globally.
2. Demonstrate understanding of how the patterns and processes of globalization make visible the interconnections and differences among and within contemporary global societies.
3. Demonstrate the development of intercultural competencies.
4. Explore individual and collective responsibilities within a global society through analytical, practical, or creative responses to problems or issues, using resources appropriate to the field.

Artificial Intelligence Tools Policy

Students may use AI tools to research topics, gather background information, and prepare for class discussions or assignments. However, AI tools should not be used to generate or write reading reactions, which must reflect the student's own understanding and original expression. Any use of AI must follow academic integrity guidelines, including proper citation when relevant. Misuse of AI tools in restricted assignments will be treated as a violation of course policies.

For a full and detailed list of GMU course policies [please click here](#).

Course calendar

Note: course calendar and activities are subject to change. Announcements of any changes will be posted on Canvas and communicated in class.

Session	Date	Title	Readings	Assignment
1	Aug-27	Economic Development and History in LatAm	Bulmer-Thomas, p. 1-42	Reading reaction 1
2	Sep-03	Institutions and Divergence	Institutions and the Historical Roots of Latin American Divergence	Reading reaction 2
3	Sep-10	Mexico	Mexico: From Crisis to Reforms and from Reforms to Crisis	Reading reaction 3
4	Sep-17	Brazil	Can poor institutions explain Brazil's economic stagnation?	Reading reaction 4
5	Sep-24	Argentina	The Argentine Disease	Reading reaction 5
6	Oct-01	Chile	Chilean Economic Development under Neoliberalism, p. 1-29	Reading reaction 6
7	Oct-08	MIDTERM		
8	Oct-15	Bolivia	Populism in Bolivia: Evo Morales	Reading reaction 7
9	Oct-22	Ecuador	The Case of Ecuador	Reading reaction 8
10	Oct-29	Colombia	Economic Development in Colombia since the early twentieth century	Reading reaction 9
11	Nov-05	Nicaragua	Unleashing Central America's Growth Potential: Nicaragua	Reading reaction 10
12	Nov-12	Venezuela	Venezuela: The Rise and Fall of a Petrostate	Reading reaction 11
13	Nov-19	Student presentations		
14	Nov-26	THANKSGIVING		
15	Dec-03	Student presentations / general review		
16	Dec-10	FINAL EXAM		